Haligric Research Integration Series

The Blue Sky and the Thirty-Seven Lords

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The Sacred Traditions of Mongolian Tengrism and Burmese Nat Worship

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Two traditions, one from the Central Asian steppe and one from the river valleys of Burma, share a single structural insight: that the world is governed not by one remote god but by a populated hierarchy of spirits requiring ongoing, practical relationship.

In Mongolia, that hierarchy begins with Tenger, the Eternal Blue Sky itself, and Etugen, the Earth Mother — a cosmology so central to Genghis Khan's own self-understanding that it shaped, by his own account, the religious tolerance of the empire he built.

In Burma, it is the Thirty-Seven Nats, a pantheon formalized eight centuries ago by royal decree, still summoned today at all-night festivals by mediums who occupy one of the only spaces in a conservative, military-ruled society where gender expression runs free.

Both traditions survived organized attempts to erase them — Soviet purges in one case, centuries of Buddhist absorption in both — and both are, in 2026, still practiced, still contested, and still very much alive.

Contents

Introduction — Two Steppe and River Cosmologies....3
Tengrism — The Eternal Blue Sky and the Earth Mother....4
The Boo and Udgan — Shamanic Practice....5
Genghis Khan, Tengrism, and Imperial Religious Tolerance....6
Soviet Suppression and the Contemporary Shamanic Revival....7
Burmese Nat Worship — The Thirty-Seven Lords....8
Min Mahagiri and Popa Medaw — Origin of the Premier Nats....9
Nat Pwe and the Natkadaw — Ceremony and Gender Inclusion....10
Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice....11
Legacy and Influence....12
Controversies and Fairness....13

Introduction — Two Steppe and River Cosmologies

Mongolian Tengrism (Mongol shamanism) and Burmese Nat worship are geographically and historically distinct traditions — one rooted in the Central Asian steppe's pastoral, nomadic cosmology, the other in Burma's riverine agricultural society — brought together in this document not because they share a lineage, but because both exemplify a widespread and often under-documented pattern in world religion: an indigenous spirit-hierarchy cosmology that persisted underneath, alongside, and in continuous negotiation with a later, more institutionally dominant religion (Tibetan Buddhism in Mongolia, Theravada Buddhism in Burma), rather than being fully replaced by it.

Both traditions remain living practices today, each having survived a distinct twentieth or twenty-first century threat to its continuity — Soviet-era religious suppression in Mongolia, and, in Burma, a complex combination of Buddhist institutional marginalization and, most recently, the military junta's persecution of the spirit mediums who serve as Nat worship's primary religious specialists.

Tengrism — The Eternal Blue Sky and the Earth Mother

Tengrism, the indigenous religious cosmology of the Mongol and wider Central Asian steppe peoples, centers on Tenger (or Tengri), the Eternal Blue Sky, understood as a supreme, largely impersonal sky-father principle governing fate and cosmic order, paired with Etugen (Itugen), the Earth Mother, whose fertility and nurturing power complements Tenger's overarching authority — a paired sky-father/earth-mother structure found in comparable form across many pastoral and agricultural cosmologies worldwide.

Fire (gal) occupies a uniquely sacred position in Mongolian cosmology as the purifying element and the literal household bridge between the human and spirit worlds; the hearth fire of a traditional ger (yurt) is treated with particular ritual respect, and specific taboos — never stepping over the hearth, never disposing of refuse into the fire, never pointing a knife at it — govern everyday household behavior around it. Mongolian shamanic cosmology traditionally describes the universe in three vertically stacked layers — an Upper World of sky spirits and ancestors, a Middle World of ordinary human and animal life, and a Lower World of chthonic and sometimes malevolent spirits — navigated ritually by the shaman.

The Boo and Udgan — Shamanic Practice

The boo (male shaman) and udgan (female shaman) are the ritual specialists of Mongolian Tengrism, understood to be called to their role through a hereditary spiritual lineage or an unsought, often illness-marked calling, and trained through apprenticeship to an established shaman rather than through any formal seminary or institutional ordination. Their central ritual function is to enter trance states — traditionally induced through drumming, chanting, and rhythmic movement — in order to travel between the three cosmological layers, communicate with ancestral and nature spirits, diagnose and treat illness understood as spiritual in origin, and mediate disputes between the human community and the spirit world.

The ovoo, a ceremonial cairn of stones (sometimes incorporating wood, prayer flags, or khadag scarves) built at mountain passes, hilltops, and other locations understood as spiritually significant, is the most widespread and publicly visible Mongolian shamanic ritual site. Ovoo worship follows a consistent structure: the worshipper circles the cairn clockwise three times, deposits an offering — food, milk, vodka, or a khadag (ceremonial blue scarf) — and may add a stone to the cairn itself, a practice understood simultaneously as an act of respect toward the local spirit-master of that particular landscape and as a request for safe travel, good fortune, or fertility.

Genghis Khan, Tengrism, and Imperial Religious Tolerance

Genghis Khan's own religious self-understanding was explicitly grounded in Tengrism: he understood his authority to rule as a direct mandate from Tenger, the Eternal Blue Sky, a claim that functioned as the Mongol Empire's core political theology and legitimating principle. Precisely because this mandate was framed in universal, sky-encompassing terms rather than through a specific institutional creed, historians widely credit Genghis Khan's Tengrist self-understanding with underpinning the Mongol Empire's unusually broad policy of religious tolerance toward the diverse populations — Buddhist, Muslim, Christian, and others — it came to rule, exempting religious clergy of all faiths from taxation and generally declining to impose Tengrism itself as a state religion upon conquered peoples.

This tolerance proved double-edged for Tengrism's own long-term institutional survival: because the tradition was never systematized into an exclusive state religion with its own competing missionary or institutional structure, it left an open field into which Tibetan Buddhism expanded decisively beginning in the sixteenth century, when Mongol ruler Altan Khan's formal alliance with the Tibetan Gelug school initiated a large-scale conversion of the Mongol nobility and, over subsequent generations, much of the wider population, from Tengrist shamanic practice toward Buddhist religious identity — a transition achieved through royal alliance and institutional patronage rather than by force.

Soviet Suppression and the Contemporary Shamanic Revival

Mongolia's twentieth-century Soviet-aligned Communist government, beginning in the 1930s, carried out a campaign of severe religious suppression targeting both Tibetan Buddhism and surviving indigenous shamanic practice; the campaign's toll on Buddhist institutions alone is documented at over thirty thousand monks killed and roughly eight hundred monasteries destroyed, and shamanic practitioners faced comparable persecution, forcing shamanic knowledge and ritual practice into private, clandestine transmission for decades.

Following Mongolia's 1990 democratic transition and the end of Communist rule, both Buddhism and Tengrist shamanism experienced a substantial public revival; shamanic practice today is estimated to be actively followed by roughly three to five percent of the Mongolian population as a primary religious identity, with a considerably larger number engaging in shamanic consultation or ovoo ritual alongside a primary Buddhist or secular identity. The Golomt Center for Shamanic Studies, founded in Ulaanbaatar in the 1990s, functions as a leading institution for the contemporary documentation, training, and public representation of Mongolian shamanic practice, working to formally preserve lineages and techniques that survived the Soviet period only through underground transmission.

Burmese Nat Worship — The Thirty-Seven Lords

Nat worship is Burma's indigenous animist tradition of spirit veneration, centering on the belief that both the natural landscape (mountains, rivers, specific trees) and significant historical or legendary individuals who suffered violent or unjust deaths become nats — powerful spirits capable of helping or harming the living, and requiring ongoing propitiation through offering and ritual respect. In the eleventh century, King Anawrahta, seeking to consolidate Buddhism as Burma's dominant religion while recognizing that outright suppression of existing nat veneration was politically unworkable, instead formally incorporated and systematized nat worship into a royally sanctioned pantheon of the Thirty-Seven Nats, placing Thagyamin — a sky-king figure syncretizing the Hindu deity Indra and the Buddhist Sakra — at its head as a Buddhist-subordinated overseer of the entire pantheon.

This royal act of incorporation rather than suppression established the enduring Burmese religious pattern in which nat veneration and Theravada Buddhist practice coexist within the same individual worshipper and the same ritual calendar, formally subordinate to Buddhism in cosmological rank (nats are understood as powerful but ultimately unenlightened beings, themselves still subject to karma and rebirth) while remaining fully active in everyday devotional life.

Min Mahagiri and Popa Medaw — Origin of the Premier Nats

The origin story of Min Mahagiri (the 'Lord of the Great Mountain') and his sister Popa Medaw ranks among the most important narratives in the Thirty-Seven Nats pantheon and directly illustrates the tradition's core theological logic — that violent, unjust death transforms ordinary humans into powerful nats. According to the traditional account, Maung Tint De, a blacksmith of extraordinary strength in the city of Tagaung, was perceived as a political threat by the reigning king, who nonetheless married Tint De's sister, Ma Myat Hla, to the king specifically as a strategy to lure her brother into custody; Tint De was captured and burned alive tied to a saga tree, and Ma Myat Hla, in her grief, threw herself into the same fire.

Both siblings became vengeful, powerful nats immediately upon their deaths, and their spirits were said to inhabit the saga tree so dangerously that anyone who came near it perished; King Thinligyaung, ruling generations later, reportedly received a dream instructing him to enshrine the two spirits properly rather than leave them as a source of unchecked harm, and had their images formally installed as guardian spirits at Mount Popa, an extinct volcanic peak that remains, to this day, the single most important pilgrimage site in Burmese Nat worship, with Min Mahagiri and Popa Medaw honored there as the pantheon's most widely venerated guardian figures.

Nat Pwe and the Natkadaw — Ceremony and Gender Inclusion

A nat pwe is a ceremonial festival, often lasting through the night, at which natkadaw (spirit mediums, literally 'nat wives,' regardless of the medium's own gender) enter trance possession by a specific nat, dance in that nat's characteristic style, wear that nat's distinctive ceremonial dress and colors, and dispense blessings, guidance, and sometimes direct requests for offerings to the assembled worshippers, accompanied by traditional hsaing waing ensemble music that shifts in character to match whichever nat is currently manifesting through the medium.

The natkadaw profession holds a distinctive and widely documented social function in Burmese society: it is one of the very few socially sanctioned, even celebrated, roles occupied predominantly by transgender women and gay men in a broader Burmese culture that otherwise affords limited public space or acceptance for gender and sexual diversity — within the nat pwe context specifically, natkadaw performers' gender expression is treated as a mark of spiritual power and legitimacy rather than a liability, a striking inversion of the marginalization these same individuals often face in day-to-day Burmese life outside the ritual context.

Self-Care, Wellness, and Daily Practice

In Mongolian Tengrist practice, everyday household ritual around the hearth fire — respecting it as sacred, never contaminating or stepping over it — functions as an ongoing, low-intensity form of spiritual maintenance folded into daily domestic life, while consultation with a boo or udgan for illness or major life decisions represents a more occasional, higher-intensity form of spiritual care, reflecting shamanic cosmology's basic premise that physical and spiritual wellbeing are a single, continuous domain rather than separate concerns.

In Burmese practice, nat veneration is frequently sought specifically for practical, this-worldly wellbeing — protection during travel, business success, healing from illness, and resolution of family conflict — pursued in parallel with, rather than instead of, formal Theravada Buddhist practice aimed at longer-term karmic and spiritual progress; for natkadaw mediums specifically, the nat pwe context additionally functions as one of the only socially available spaces for authentic gender expression and community belonging, a form of psychological and social wellbeing distinctive to this tradition's particular social position.

Legacy and Influence

Mongolian Tengrist cosmology's sky-father/earth-mother structure and its shamanic ritual technologies of trance, drumming, and spirit mediation continue to inform broader Central Asian shamanic revival movements well beyond Mongolia's own borders, and the ovoo cairn, as a public and highly visible ritual form, remains one of the most widely recognized symbols of surviving indigenous Mongolian spirituality both domestically and internationally.

The Thirty-Seven Nats pantheon and the institution of the nat pwe festival remain deeply woven into everyday Burmese cultural and religious life, and the natkadaw tradition's role as a space of gender and sexual minority visibility has drawn growing international scholarly and human-rights attention as a distinctive, indigenous counter-example to the assumption that South and Southeast Asian religious traditions are uniformly restrictive on questions of gender expression.

Controversies and Fairness

Mongolia's twentieth-century experience of religious suppression under Soviet-aligned rule — with its documented toll of over thirty thousand monks killed and roughly eight hundred monasteries destroyed — remains a significant and openly acknowledged chapter in the country's national religious memory, one that the post-1990 shamanic and Buddhist revival has been explicitly understood, within Mongolia itself, as a form of restoration and redress rather than novel invention.

In Burma, the natkadaw community has, since the February 2021 military coup, become an unexpected site of open political dissent: individual mediums have publicly prayed against and cursed the junta during nat pwe ceremonies, with the medium known as Achaintan Man Gay Oo's public condemnation of military rule drawing wide attention, and the sorcerer Linn Nhyo Taryar was arrested and sentenced to two years' imprisonment specifically for praying against the junta — a direct instance of the military government treating a traditional ritual practice as a punishable political act.

This persecution sits within a wider and independently documented pattern of anti-LGBTQ pressure under junta rule: an Outright International report released in September 2024 and a United Nations Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights report from July 2024 both documented intensified discrimination and violence against LGBTQ individuals in Burma since the coup, alongside junta book-banning campaigns targeting LGBTQ-themed literature — developments that place additional pressure on the very natkadaw community whose ritual role has historically depended on exactly the gender and sexual diversity now facing heightened state hostility.

Closing

An ovoo cairn on a Mongolian hillside and a nat shrine at the foot of a Burmese banyan tree do not look like the same religious act, but both mark the same underlying claim: that the land itself is inhabited, and that a relationship with what inhabits it has to be tended, not assumed.

The Golomt Center for Shamanic Studies in Ulaanbaatar and the natkadaw mediums who still gather at Mount Popa despite the risks of doing so under military rule are, each in their own idiom, the present-tense evidence that neither tradition is a museum piece.

Grand rising to the keepers of the Blue Sky and the Thirty-Seven Lords — the ovoo is still circled, and the nat pwe still calls its dancers.